Chapter Four

That Was the Week That Was

‘[I] was told more barefaced lies than I have ever heard in so short a time.’[1]

(John F. Kennedy)

‘They can attack us and we shall we respond. We may end in a big war.’[2]

(Nikita Khrushchev)

‘[A nuclear exchange] would leave the US in a seriously damaged condition, with many millions of casualties and little immediate war supporting capability [but] the US would continue to exist as an organised and viable nation, and ultimately would prevail, whereas the USSR would not.’[3]

(US Joint Chiefs of Staff)

On Monday, 22 October 1962 the United States government publicly threatened a full-scale nuclear attack upon the Soviet Union. At 7.00pm Eastern Daylight Time (EDT), President John F. Kennedy took to US television and radio networks to announce the discovery of Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba. The United States, he explained, would begin ‘a strict quarantine on all offensive military equipment under shipment to Cuba,’ and warned, ‘It shall be the policy of this nation to regard any nuclear missile launched from Cuba against any